FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

India is not short of dynastic stories, but this one carries a special note of fascination. For, Tejashwi Yadav, the protagonist, is the son of Lalu Prasad Yadav, who was a mould-breaker in terms of his personality as well as his politics. Tejashwi was a four-month-old infant when Lalu first took power as Bihar's chief minister, inaugurating a long reign around the radical and disruptive slogan of Mandal. Thirty-five years later, the son is the closest he has ever been to occupying the same chair. Anointed as the chief ministerial candidate of the Mahagathbandhan (MGB), he is the face of the campaign against an entrenched incumbent, the Nitish Kumar-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA). To make the last mile, the young Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) chief has armed himself with a strategic blend of social and economic drivers. Its grid is a rainbow caste alliance, an expanded version of the Mandal formula that once underwrote Lalu's reign. Animating that is a grandiose jobs-for-all pitch and high welfarism that taps into the present and future anxieties of a 74 million-strong electorate, especially its massive youth component.

As Bihar races towards a humdinger of an assembly election, the final steps of the electoral math are still a puzzle. But Tejashwi has grabbed the momentum due to a combination of circumstances. Nitish is a name most politicians across the ages have wanted on their side. Both alliances in Bihar have prospered in his company. But after 20 years of being at the helm, age and anti-incumbency could be catching up with the Janata Dal (United) helmsman. Besides, the NDA has still not explicitly endorsed him for the top post, leaving his eventual fate in a limbo. And there is no one of comparable stature in the BJP, the NDA's biggest component in Bihar. Against this indeterminacy, the MGB's strategic clarity, a bare fortnight before voting, has catalysed the field.

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However, Tejashwi's legacy is both an asset and a liability. The NDA has worked hard to revive the phobia of Lalu's 'jungle raj', which is deeply embedded in Bihar's collective memory. For years, this fear has driven counter-consolidation, among the elite castes whose old domination was challenged violently by Yadav power, as well as the non-Yadav Other Backward Classes (OBCs) and the Extremely Backward Classes (EBCs) who rallied around Nitish for two decades. This psychological resistance translates into a stiff numerical challenge for Tejashwi. The old Muslim-Yadav (M-Y) base of the RJD adds up to a formidable 32 per cent, but it has never been sufficient without a good portion of the 36 per cent EBC and 20 per cent Dalit cohorts joining in. Can Tejashwi bridge that gap and overcome the repellent force that still operates on those groups? Aware of this handicap, he repeatedly pledges he will tolerate no wrongdoing, not even from those closest to him.

Backing this reformative promise is the 'A to Z' caste formula. This seeks to replace the old M-Y duopoly of the RJD with a big tent that offers food and shelter to a wide spectrum of caste groups. Besides Tejashwi, the MGB has projected Vikassheel Insaan Party chief Mukesh Sahani, the 'son of Mallah', as its deputy CM face. Mallahs may be only a 2 per cent vote, but as a boatman caste, they are spread out across Bihar's riverine landscape. The gesture itself is rich in symbolism, with more EBC/Dalit faces promised at that level, and over half of the RJD's tickets going to non-M-Y groups, further burnished by its 23 women candidates, the highest among all parties. Lending all this a ring of sincerity is the presence of Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, who seems to have rekindled the dormant Congress base with his turn towards Ambedkarite social justice and *vote chori* campaign. The party's Bihar president, Rajesh Ram, belongs to the Ravidasia Dalit community (5 per cent) and the Congress is not seen as the weak link, as in 2020.

To outdo the NDA's potpourri of attractive poll sops, Tejashwi has pledged to provide one state job to every family that lacks one, among other enticements. In a state where chronic unemployment has seen hordes of Biharis migrate to other states, this should be a powerful pull factor. But with Tejashwi's pledge likely to cost around Rs 12 lakh crore, or four times Bihar's annual budget, it has been dubbed by the NDA as a "fiscal fantasy". Also, Bihar is often won and lost on extremely thin margins, with about 50 out of its 243 assembly seats decided by margins below 5,000 votes. In his first outing at the helm of MGB, Tejashwi himself had come close to clinching the 2020 election: the alliance fell only 12,000 votes short of the NDA's tally. He comes into his second inning with his punch and panache intact, but wiser and more mature. As a one-time dabbler in cricket, his highest first-class score was 19. In politics, he needs to pilot the MGB to score more than a century of seats, with 122 being the majority mark. Will he succeed? This week's cover story reads the compelling contest unfolding in Bihar via a spotlight on the Tejashwi persona. Senior Editor Amitabh Srivastava sees in it both promise and paradox and says, "Without doubt, this is the youthful RJD leader's biggest test."

(Aroon Purie)